safeguards, known as Permissive Action Links (PALS), were only starting to be installed on US nuclear weapons.

So, was it Kennedy's secret offer to remove the Turkish Jupiters that brought the crisis to an end? Quite a few historians believe so, including, most recently, Theodore Voorhees, in *The Silent Guns of Two Octobers.* If so, the lessons to be learned are surely very different than if the traditional narrative holds sway that Kennedy stood firm (while still building his golden bridge). Or, on the other hand, was the threat that the US would likely start bombing the missile sites in the next day or so the key? Or was it indeed a combination of the two?

The short answer is that neither were crucial to the outcome. As noted, the Presidium had agreed to withdraw the R-12s from Cuba on Thursday, 25 October, subject to US assurances not to attack Cuba. JFK provided those assurances in the letter to Khrushchev that his brother handed to Dobrynin on Saturday, 27 October. In addition, thanks to the work of Fursenko and Naftali, it is possible to trace with rare precision how Dobrynin's report of his meeting with RFK reached Khrushchev and the Presidium.

On the morning of Sunday, 28 October the Soviet Premier assembled his colleagues in the Presidium at a *dacha* in the suburbs of Moscow. He told them:

> There was a time, when we advanced like in October 1917; but in March 1918 we had to retreat, having signed the Brest-Litovsk agreement with the Germans. Our interests dictated this decision – we had to save Soviet power. Now we found [sic] ourselves face to face with the danger of war and of nuclear catastrophe, with the possible result of destroying the human race. In order to save the world, we must retreat. I called you together to consult and debate whether you are in agreement with this kind of decision.[69]

There is no indication of any dissent. It was nevertheless agreed that General Pliyev should use force to repel an invasion. What that might mean